CHAPTER 5 The Tool: The Grateful Flow The Higher Force: Gratefulness

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Subject	**CHAPTER 5 The Tool: The Grateful Flow The Higher Force: Gratefulness**
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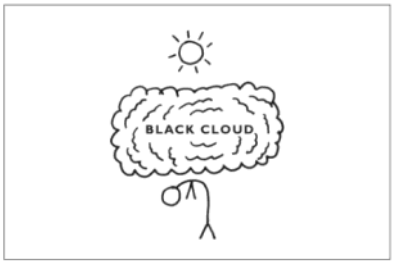
THE BLACK CLOUD

We like to think we react to the world as it is, when really we react to a world that exists in our own minds. This inner wor ld is so powerful, it overwhelms our ability to see reality. John Milton, in *Paradise Lost*, expressed it this way: "The mind is its own place, and in itself / Can make a Heav'n of Hell, a Hell of Heav'n." We call th is presence the "Black Cloud." When you worry incessantly, regardless of the subject, you're creating a negative energy that hangs over you like a cloud. The Black Cloud s creens out everything positive and creates a sense of impending doom. It makes no difference if the doom comes through natural disaster, disease, or human error. Its power doesn't come from the truth of its predictions—they're almost always false. The Black Cloud dominates us in a much more primal way—through the force of repetition. If you repeat something enough times, it becomes a habit with a life of its own —it's easier to do it than not.

You can have your own experience of the Black Cloud. Start by picking something you typically worry about. Maybe it's your jo b, a troubled child, or a parent who's unwell.

Close your eyes and re-create the worried thoughts, repeating them intensely like you do in real life. At first, this might feel artificial, but if you keep at it, the thoughts will gain momentum and acquire a life of their own. Now, focus on the inner state that these thoughts have created. What does it feel like?

You just experienced a mild version of the Black Cloud. When it occurs in your actual life, it's darker and more oppressive. By blotting out everything positive, it convinces you that only the negative is real. The following illustration depicts the Black Cloud at work:



Above the cloud is the sun, the universal symbol for the positive. Here, it would represent all that is right in the world. We've drawn the Black Cloud as an impenetrable shroud that keeps out the positive. The sun is still shining, but for the person under the cloud, it doesn't exist. There is no joy; only negativity. H e's bent over by the heaviness of the dark world his thoughts have created. There's a huge price to pay for living this way.

For the person crushed by the Black Cloud, there can be no peace of mind.

THE PRICE OF NEGATIVITY

For most of us, peace of mind is a precious feeling. It is the sense that everything is in its right place, that "all is well ." You've felt this in fleeting moments—everyone has—an inner serenity, a sense that you're in harmony with all of existence. The Black Cloud annihilates this sense of peace. Under its spell, all you can s ee is what's not right with the world. Any kind of negative thinking can do this —hopelessness, self-hatred, judgmentalism—but worry does it best. Without a sense of serenity, everything becomes a crisis. With all your energy focused on survival, e njoying life is a luxury you can't afford.

WHY IS NEGATIVE THINKING SO POWERFUL?

It's tempting to think we can change our thought patterns easily. After all, why can't we just replace each negative thought with a positive one? This idea has always been part of American culture, reaching its peak with a book called *The Power of Positive Thinking*. Unfortunately, it's one of those ideas that seems like it would work but doesn't. It fails because, *in real life, positive thoughts don't have anywhere near the power that negative thoughts do*. In essence, worry had become a powerful superstition—with no more real benefit than a rabbit's foot. But superstitions have a powerful appeal because they give us a magical sense that we can affect the future. Of course, this is an illusion —most of life is beyond our ability to predict, much less control. From a picnic getting rained out to a sudden heart attack—anything can happen at any time. Still, we insist we can control the uncontrollable.

Why?

Because of a basic assumption about the universe that we never question. We assume (because science tells us so) that the universe is indifferent to us. Based only on what we see aro und us, this is a reasonable conclusion. But it makes us feel alone in a universe that doesn't care about us. Feeling we won't be pro vided for, we become obsessed with controlling our future. In that context, worrying seems to make sense. But what if, on a level we can't see, the universe *is* interested in our welfare, supporting us in ways large and small? It's not that much of a stretch to be able to perceive this. Start with your physical body. It extracts oxygen from the air, it digests complex foods, it allows yo u the miracle of sight and hearing. All these things work amazingly well without your even understanding how. There's more—the earth supplies us with food, the air we breathe; and it gives us the raw materials with which to build things. And these are just a few examples of the infinite number of ways our existence is sustained by the universe.

TOOL: THE GRATEFUL FLOW

There are times in everyone's life when the Source makes its presence known so powerfully that we feel grateful without any e ffort on our part. For you, it might have happened while camping out under a starry sky; or maybe when your child was born. What makes these moments truly special is the deep feeling that so mething was being given to you; something you couldn't have created yourself. Think back to some time this happened in your life, and re-create the experience right now, with your eyes closed.

Visualize everything that was happening around you. Focus on the gratefulness you were feeling at the time. Now, connect that gratefulness to the presence of an unimaginably generous force.

Many of us have experienced the Source this way. But no matter how powerfully we felt it, it happened under special circumsta nces that can rarely be re-created. If you're serious about defeating your negativity, you need access to the Source at all times, no matter what the circumstances. The only way to gain that acce ss is to learn to activate your sense of gratefulness at will.

Here's the tool to awaken the organ of gratefulness.

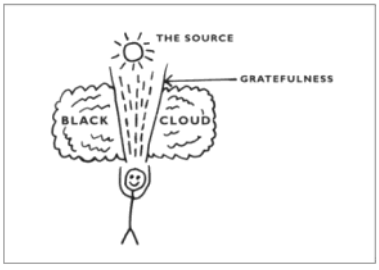
The Grateful Flow

Pick out things in your life you can be grateful for—particularly things you'd normally take for granted. Say them to yourself silently, slowly enough to feel the value of each one. "I'm grateful for my eyesight; I'm grateful I have hot water," etc. You should do this until you've mentioned at least five items—it takes less than thirty seconds. Feel the slight strain of your effort to find these items.

You should feel the gratefulness you express flowing upward, directly from your heart. Then, when you've finished mentioning the specific items, your heart should continue to generate gratefulness, this time without words. The energy you are now giving out is the Grateful Flow.

As this energy emanates from your heart, your chest will soften and open. In this state you'll feel yourself approaching an overwhelming presence, filled with the power of infinite giving. You've made a connection to the Source.

The picture below shows how the tool works. It creates a sense of gratefulness that's so powerful it penetrates the Black Clo ud. This is illustrated by the channel that extends upward from the person, splitting the Cloud. The small lines inside the channel represent the force of gratefulness, flowing upward. The suns hining above the Cloud represented whatever was right with the world. Now we can give the sun its proper name: the Source, the creator of all that is, the ultimate positive force in the universe. This picture shows how gratefulness becomes an organ that connects us to the Source.



We call the tool the "Grateful Flow." *Flow* refers to any process that's endlessly creative. In the tool, you create an endless flow of thoughts to stimulate an endless flow of gratefulness, which affirms the ceaseless generosity of the Source. Since flow is always creating, it has a quality of constant renewal. That's w hy it's important to name different items you're grateful for each time you use the tool. Coming up with at least a few new items each time requires effort, but it's a sacred effort that keeps you deeply connected to the Source.

At first it might seem difficult to come up with things you're grateful for, but it's easier than you think. You can use thin gs that aren't happening, such as "I'm grateful I'm not in a war zone" or "I'm grateful I don't live on the San Andreas fault." And you can also mine your past for items, such as "I'm grateful I went to a good high school" or "I'm grateful my mother loved me." Stick to things you're truly grateful for, not things you feel you *should* be grateful for. These are often minor things that you might not notice unless they were taken away—like the fact that you had a nice lunch with a friend, for example, or that your electricity works. Patients often ask why we emphasize these minor items. The answer is simple: although we tend to take them for granted, *they're always there*. By forcing us to be aware and appreciative of them, the tool reminds us that *the Source is always there as well—sustaining us in an unimaginable number of ways*.

When you're learning the tool, start by mechanically naming things you're grateful for. Once you get used to that, try to fee l gratefulness emanating from your heart as you name the specific things. Once you can feel that, then you can stop the words for a moment and train your heart to generate pure gratefulness without words. It's that final state t hat will open you up to the presence of the Source. After some practice you'll move seamlessly through the tool. Then you can start using it in daily lif e.

When you go about your day, pay attention to your thoughts. At the first sign of negative thinking, use the Grateful Flow; ne gativity is your cue. Remember, the purpose of a cue is to get you to use the tool immediately, even if it doesn't seem urgent. This is particularly important with the Grateful Flow because negat ive thinking puts most of us into the Black Cloud without our even being aware of it. The Grateful Flow is so important, you should also make it a daily practice. One way to do this is to use the to ol at specific times throughout the day. Many patients use it first thing when they wake up, with each meal, and last thing before they fall asleep.

You can also use it whenever your mind is undirected, which can happen throughout the day—while riding the bus, taking a coffee break, or standing in line at a convenience store. Once you use the Grateful Flow at these times, you'll see how undisciplined the mind is. Left to its own devices, it degenerates, filling itse lf with trivia, insecurity, and negativity.

The point of using the Grateful Flow so frequently is to make you the master of your own mind, the only thing a human being c an really control. *Until you can control your mind, you're spiritually immature*. As children, we need parents to make us brush our teeth and wash ourselves every day. As adults, we accept our responsibili ty for these things without question. With practice, you'll bring the same diligence to your spiritual hygiene as you do to your physical hygiene. At that point you'll become a spiritua l adult. When gratefulness becomes a way of life, the Source becomes a constant companion. The ancients expressed this companionship in very personal terms. In Psalm 23 King David wrote: "Yea, t hough I walk through the valley of the shadow of death, / I will fear no evil, / for Thou art with me; Thy rod and Thy staff, they comfort me." Living in modern times, you might not experience the Source in such an inti mate, personal way, but you will feel the kind of comfort, support, and nurturing that King David expressed so eloquently.

THE SECRET BENEFITS OF CONNECTING TO THE SOURCE

Peace of mind eludes almost everyone in the modern world because we look for it in the wrong place. We think it will come fro m some external accomplishment—enough money to retire on, a vacation home, a loyal spouse. But even if we achieve these goals, the peace of mind they give us is short -lived. The reason is simple. In the material world, you're always vulnerable; whatever you gain you can also lose. The stock market can crash, a flood can wash away your home, your spouse can leave you. For peace of mind to be la sting, therefore, it must come from someplace where you are always nurtured and supported.

Lasting peace of mind can only come from a connection to the Source.

But for it to be really lasting, the connection has to be *ongoing*—which means you have to keep working on it. This is counterintuitive. Normally we envision peace of mind as a resting state. But that isn't peace, it's passivity. Because it requires constant work to stay connected to the Source—*peace of mind is an active state*.

This is a lot of work, but it's worth it. One benefit is a dramatic increase in energy and motivation. Most people have a fau lty way of motivating themselves. They're motivated to get whatever they want—money, romance, status—because they feel they don't have enough already. This feeling of lack is a powerful motivator, but you pay a huge price for it. That price is the ongoing feeling that there's *always something missing*. Even if you get something you've wanted, you quickly become dissatisfied with it, which then motivates you to get something else. You can never be happy on this treadmill. Eventually, it sucks the meaning and energy out of your life.

The flaw in this way of motivating yourself is that you have to generate all the energy yourself. The alternative is to conne ct to an energy source much bigger than you, the true wellspring of all energy, the Source. You can't use the sense of something missing in order to plug into the Source. In fact, the more grateful you feel for what you already have, the more energy you get from it. Your gratitude opens the door to a completely new way of living in which the energy to move forward is based on happiness ins tead of misery.

The Grateful Flow is a direct acknowledgment of the Source as a co-creator in everything you achieve. Only this acknowledgment allows you to remain humble in the midst of success, which

then enables you to remain creative for the rest of your life.
The Source *is* always working to help us, but it often doesn't feel that way. The Source sees in us the limitless potential to create new th ings. With this creative power, we can reshape the world. But the human ego misunderstands this power. It sees creation only in terms of proving its own importance. To maintain that i llusion, it claims that it creates everything on its own, without help; it denies that the Source even exists. That isn't just wrong, it prevents us from ever fulfilling our potential. We do have the ability to create without end, but *we create nothing alone*. Each new thing humans bring to the world—everything from a new baby to a new technology—is done using the infinite energy of the Source. Our future potential doesn't lie in doing everything ourselves, it lies in t he ability to co-create with the Source.

The Source is relentless in forcing us to realize this potential. It does this by destroying our illusion that we're the mast ers of the universe—and the go-it-alone mentality that comes with it. It doesn't do this with logic*, it does it with events*. It brings events into our lives that we don't want and can't control: illness, failure, rejection. The pain of these events brings us to our knees, forcing us to admit we're not the most powerful force in the universe. This is a blessing. It opens us up to our true higher potential —our partnership with the Source.

This reveals the hidden, higher meaning of adversity. Behind even the worst events, the Source is working for our welfare. Wh en I explain this to my patients, they want to believe it. But as soon as things get really tough, they lose any sense that their pain has meaning. All they feel is that they're being unfairly pun ished. At this point, I encourage them to look outside themselves. If they do, they'll see an endless number of human beings suffering even worse adversity; and among them will always be some who aren 't crushed by life, who remain buoyant and good-natured. These people seem to have an extraordinary ability to enjoy life and to radiate goodwill. Adversity hasn't dimmed their inner life—it has made it stronger.

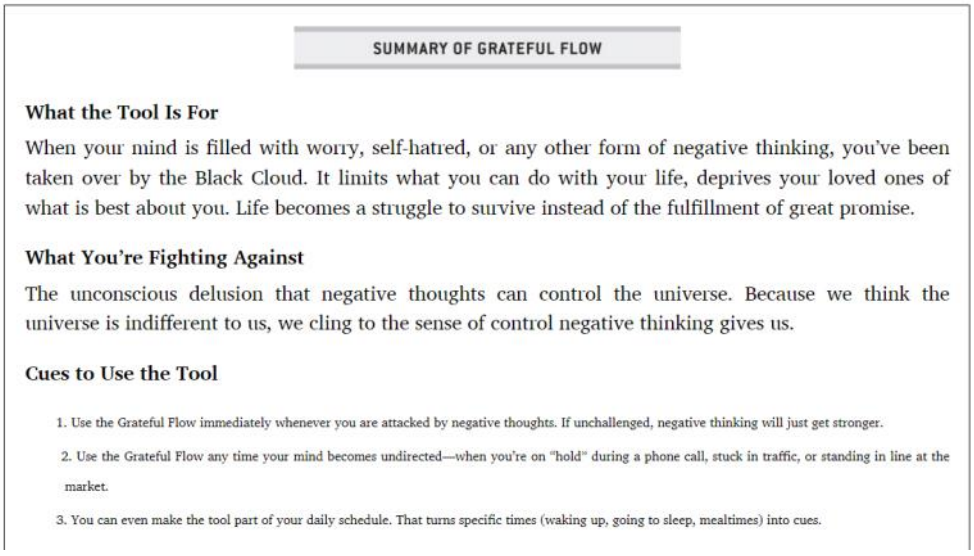
This group senses the real purpose of adversity. Instead of resisting fate, they allow it to break down their egos. Consequently, as things get worse, their connection to the Source gets stronger. They radiate light in the darkest circumstances. And there has been no darker circumstance than that which Viktor Frankl desc ribed in his masterpiece, *Man's Search for Meaning* . As you remember, he was a physician imprisoned in four different concentration camps during the Holocaust. Stripped of his position, family, and possessions, his life threatened on a daily basis, he set himself a goal of finding a sense of higher purpose in his situation. His success created a beacon of higher meaning that ins pired those around him.

OTHER USES OF THE GRATEFUL FLOW

The Grateful Flow frees you from regrets about the past. *Many of us fall into the habit of rethinking past decisions we've made, blaming those decisions for everything bad that's hap pened since. Besides the fact that life isn't that simple, this kind of regret makes it impossible to move forward into the future. You need a tool that allows you a renewed sense of possibilities right now; only then can you leave the past behind you*.

The Grateful Flow frees you from self-hatred. *Self-hatred rarely has anything to do with your actual value as a person. It's the direct result of a stream of negative thoughts about yourself. Usually, these take the form of criticisms delivered by a harsh inner voice. This inner critic speaks with such authority tha t there's no reasoning with it. You need a tool that silences its voice altogether*.

The Grateful Flow stops you from being judgmental about others. *When we judge others, we kid ourselves that what we think privately has no effect on those around us. The truth is that judgments, especially repeated harsh judgments, send an energy into the world that alienates others. You can't fake a nonjudg mental attitude; you actually have to eliminate the judgments themselves*.



SUMMARY OF GRATEFUL FLOW

What the Tool Is For

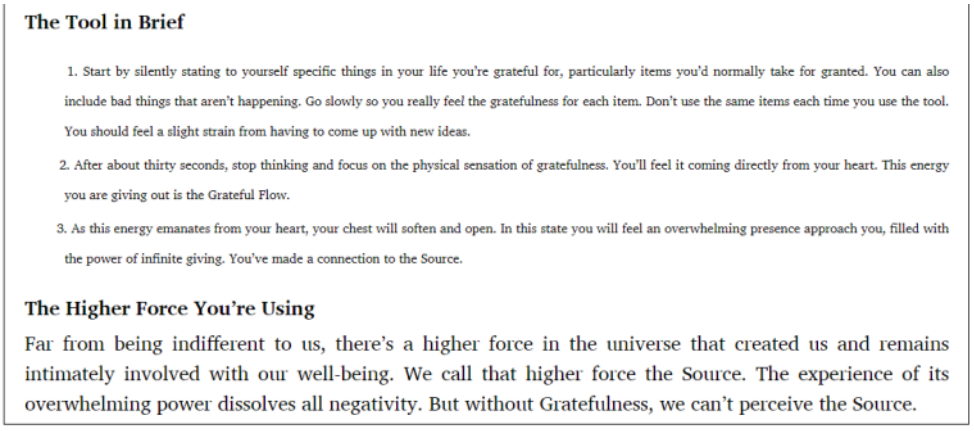
When your mind is filled with worry, self-hatred, or any other form of negative thinking, you've been taken over by the Black Cloud. It limits what you can do with your life, deprives your loved ones of what is best about you. Life becomes a struggle to survive instead of the fulfillment of great promise.

What You're Fighting Against

The unconscious delusion that negative thoughts can control the universe. Because we think the universe is indifferent to us, we cling to the sense of control negative thinking gives us.

Cues to Use the Tool

1. Use the Grateful Flow immediately whenever you are attacked by negative thoughts. If unchallenged, negative thinking will just get stronger.
2. Use the Grateful Flow any time your mind becomes undirected—when you're on "hold" during a phone call, stuck in traffic, or standing in line at the market.
3. You can even make the tool part of your daily schedule. That turns specific times (waking up, going to sleep, mealtimes) into cues.



The Tool in Brief

1. Start by silently stating to yourself specific things in your life you're grateful for, particularly items you'd normally take for granted. You can also include bad things that aren't happening. Go slowly so you really feel the gratefulness for each item. Don't use the same items each time you use the tool. You should feel a slight strain from having to come up with new ideas.
2. After about thirty seconds, stop thinking and focus on the physical sensation of gratefulness. You'll feel it coming directly from your heart. This energy you are giving out is the Grateful Flow.
3. As this energy emanates from your heart, your chest will soften and open. In this state you will feel an overwhelming presence approach you, filled with the power of infinite giving. You've made a connection to the Source.

The Higher Force You're Using

Far from being indifferent to us, there's a higher force in the universe that created us and remains intimately involved with our well-being. We call that higher force the Source. The experience of its overwhelming power dissolves all negativity. But without Gratefulness, we can't perceive the Source.